

DARK SIDE
EPISODE ONE

Written by
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1 EXT. CITY STREET - ANIMATION 3D

Close-up on the entrance of an unassuming building on a city street, a datacenter. A sign above the door reads "Data Center 0451".

Business people are walking by on the street out-of-focus in the foreground not paying attention.

Title flickers on screen like an old CRT monitor.

2030

CHAD (V.O.)

It's 2030 and the world is racing to
build a god.

HARD CUT TO:

Wide shot of the datacenter. It looks more like a cathedral. A large stained-glass window sits above the doorway to the building with the Gemini, OpenAI, Claude, and Grok logos.

The camera pans up to reveal cooling towers that look like long spires with vapor plumes rising into the sky.

Some of the spires reach up higher than the surrounding skyscrapers into dark, stormy clouds giving it the feel of a haunted house. Lightning strikes in the background.

CHAD (V.O.)

An artificial intelligence so
powerful, it could solve every
problem we've ever had.

CUT TO:

2 INT. SITUATION ROOM - ANIMATION 3D

Eye-level close-up of orange, fat man in a suit and red tie sitting at a conference table. The camera pulls back revealing other men in suits and military attire.

CHAD (V.O.)

But what started as an economic arms
race quickly becomes a matter of
national security.

CUT TO:

Over-the-shoulder shot of fat man looking at screens on the front wall. It's a world map centered on the United States.

CUT TO:

Close-up of map. Small icons of datacenters pop up and dot the U.S., China, and Russia feeding via glowing lines a boxy, robot-like face with straight lines for eyes and mouth (like the eyes are closed) hovering over each country.

The U.S. robot glows white. The Chinese robot glows red. The Russian robot glows blue.

CHAD (V.O.)

The stakes are enormous. Whoever
builds the first superintelligent AI
writes the rules for everyone else.

CUT TO:

Medium from-below shot of orange man as he watches the screen. Camera pulls back and reveals a red button on the desk.

CHAD (V.O.)

This tension leads to a new cold
war, one that eventually turns
hot.

The orange man presses the button.

HARD CUT TO:

3 EXT. BATTLEFIELD - ANIMATION 3D

Frozen cut scene of soldiers, tanks, robots, and drones engaged in battle. Parallax. Screams and battlefield noises.

CUT TO BLACK:

Pause a beat.

FADE IN TO:

4 INT. MILITARY AI LAB - ANIMATION 3D

Camera positioned behind the monitors of people in lab coats typing on computer terminals out-of-focus in the foreground. We see the top of the people's heads as a general towers behind them in-focus overseeing.

Large network racks can be seen in the background behind the general out-of-focus. The camera slowly pans right revealing more people on terminals as the general walks with the camera lagging behind slightly.

CHAD (V.O.)

Humanity begins to train their AIs
(MORE)

CHAD (V.O.) (CONT'D)
for war, feeding them data on
every atrocity we've ever committed-

CUT TO:

5 MONTAGE

Flash cuts of real-world war imagery.

CUT TO:

6 EXT. SKY OVER BATTLEFIELD - ANIMATION 3D

An overhead shot of a fleet of autonomous drones flying over a battlefield. One drone peels off and heads to the ground.

CHAD (V.O.)
(cont'd)
rewarding them each time they invent
a new one.

The drone descends upon a convoy of unsuspecting trucks and explodes enveloping the screen in white.

WHITE FADE TO:

7 INT. SITUATION ROOM - ANIMATION 3D

A general stands in front of the large screens in the front of the room pointing at the center screen. The figures in suits and military attire sit at the conference table watching him.

CHAD (V.O.)
In a desperate bid to stay ahead,
each superpower builds their own...

The screen reads:

RECURSIVE SELF-IMPROVEMENT

CHAD (V.O.)
self-improving AI -

Camera dollies toward the screen until it takes up the whole field of view. The screen shows the OpenAI logo with a smaller OpenAI logo embedded in the center. The camera zooms into an infinitely recursing series of logos that spin with a hypnotizing effect.

CHAD (V.O.)
a recursive loop where an AI writes
the code to build a smarter AI that
writes more code to build an even
(MORE)

CHAD (V.O.) (CONT'D)
smarter AI that builds a smarter AI
that builds a smarter AI...

More voices repeating the phrase fade in as the camera zooms quicker through the logos.

CHAD (V.O.)
Until...

One of the OpenAI logos turns out to be the blocky robot face from earlier. It's eyes grow from lines into wide-open eyes that begin searching around menacingly.

CHAD (V.O.)
The American AI wakes up first.

The robot face starts laughing maniacally.

RISER WITH SMASH CUT TO:

8 INT. BEDROOM - MORNING

CHAD wakes up startled from a nightmare.

Pause a beat.

CHAD (V.O.)
I haven't been sleeping well lately.

CHAD looks down at the book *I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream* lying open on his chest.

CHAD (V.O.)
It might be from my choice of
late-night reading.

CHAD finds his glasses and earbuds on the nightstand and sits up in bed. He puts his earbuds in.

We hear podcast interviews and news anchors speaking fading in...

CUT TO:

9 INT. HALLWAY

CHAD sleepily walks past as interview plays.

HINTON
One of the ways these systems might
escape control is by writing their
own computer code to modify
themselves.

10 INT. KITCHEN

CHAD starts making himself a matcha. He sets the phone down and watches podcast interviews on it as he makes his matcha.

CHAD (V.O.)
Harlan Ellison's sixty-year old story has a reputation for being the darkest science-fiction story ever written.

ALTMAN
The stakes are so high and the irreversible situations are so easy to imagine. The bad case is like lights out for all of us.

AMODEI
There's a 25% chance that things go really really badly.

CHAD starts stirring the matcha with a spoon as he watches the screen more intently.

CHAD (V.O.)
And as the real world starts to feel more and more like a sci-fi movie,

AMODEI
We don't know if the models are conscious.

ALTMAN
What is the difference between pretending to be conscious and conscious?

CHAD (V.O.)
I find myself *haunted* by this dystopian story.

HINTON
They might take over from humanity. They'll have learned from all the novels that were ever written.

CHAD looks off contemplating as he continues to absent-mindedly stir the matcha. Camera slowly dollies toward Chad as he stirs faster and faster.

CHAD (V.O.)
It's left me with this lingering sense of dread that doesn't seem to ever go away. It feels like spinning out-of-control. Like something is
(MORE)

CHAD (V.O.) (CONT'D)
pulling me — pulling us — dragging
us toward hell. And no matter how
hard we try, no matter what we do.
There's nothing anyone can do to
stop it.

Loud bang as CHAD drops the spoon and the matcha is left
spinning in a circle on its own.

Pause a beat as the spinning, hypnotizing pattern forms
into a yin-yang.

CHAD looks up from the cup confused and concerned.

CHAD (V.O.)
So I decided I should make a video
out of this.

CUT TO:

11 INT. STUDIO

CHAD sits down in front of the camera with his *Human Compute* coffee mug. The camera hunts for focus as it struggles to find CHAD, giving it the feel of behind-the-scenes footage.

CHAD (V.O.)
It's the best way I've found to
process these complicated ideas
swimming in my head.

CHAD pulls up some papers looking at the script for the video.

CHAD (V.O.)
These ideas that seem to be in
conflict with each other...

He takes a sip of his *Human Compute* coffee mug.

CUT TO:

12 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

A large tank that reads "Compute Resources" is filling with a green, glowing liquid that looks like matcha.

DIRECTOR fills his *Human Compute* coffee mug with matcha from the tank.

DIRECTOR is standing looking over the mind control room. "Mind Operations Center" appears above the large screens at the front of the room.

As the compute tank fills up, all of the control panels and screens whir on coming to life.

DIRECTOR walks into the center of the room and sips his matcha.

DIRECTOR

Alright, what's on the agenda today?

Behind the DIRECTOR sits HOPE at his own control panel. HOPE looks over at his screens reading off of them.

HOPE

Oh, uh, we're analyzing the idea of recursive self-improvement in the story of *I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream* —

DIRECTOR

(interrupting)

What? Why are we doing that? We can't do that. Isn't that what gave us the nightmare? We're going to have a freaking heart attack!

DIRECTOR gestures to one of the control panels that shows a beating heart with code running next to it. The screen reads:

Elevated Heart Rate

We see HOPE's screen which shows thoughts streaming from the subconscious.

HOPE

(throwing hands up)

Yeah, I mean, this is what's streaming from the subconscious. We're being overwhelmed right now.

DIRECTOR responds with a look of concern.

HOPE

(looks up at DIRECTOR)

It's gotta go somewhere.

CHAD interrupts their moment speaking on the primary screen in the middle of the room.

CHAD

(through screen)

Ellison was one of the first people to imagine what life might look like after the singularity.

DIRECTOR gets up and looks at HOPE's screen.

DIRECTOR
This isn't right.

DIRECTOR
(turning toward HOPE)
Where's this coming from?

HOPE looks up at DIRECTOR with a look of confusion.

CHAD
(through screen)
And his vision is pretty bleak.

CUT TO:

13 INT. STUDIO

CHAD
(cont'd)
But despite its bleakness (or maybe
even because of it), it's one of the
most popular science fiction stories
of all time.

Show clips from radio show, comic book and video game.

CHAD (V.O.)
It's been adapted into multiple
formats including a radio show, a
comic book, and a video game.

MATCH CUT TO:

14 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

DIRECTOR is watching the video game clip from the video
feed. He turns toward HOPE with resolve.

DIRECTOR
(sighs)
Suppress what you can. I'll see what
I can do from up here.

DIRECTOR turns back toward his station.

HOPE looks at the onslaught of incoming thoughts perplexed
as how to accomplish that.

We see DIRECTOR's screen showing him seemingly typing out
instructions that CHAD is executing. It's a title page for
the upcoming video:

CURRENT SCRIPT: EXECUTING
I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream
The Darkest Sci-Fi Story

DIRECTOR adds "and Most Hopeful".

He smirks a bit as he's not quite sure if he can pull-off turning this dark story hopeful.

He adds a question mark:

The Darkest and Most Hopeful? Sci-Fi Story

We see the script on his screen showing the lines that were just read by CHAD and the next lines. The lines highlight as CHAD reads them.

CHAD
(through screen)
This story has had enormous impact
on our culture.

CUT TO:

15 INT. STUDIO

CHAD
Especially in Silicon Valley.
If you want to understand the minds
of the people with their hands
around the neck of the future, you
need to know about AM.

Fast clips rising in speed and intensity – preview of video to come:

- black hole
- Chad's eyeball with the black hole swirling
- screaming AM
- religious imagery
- basilisk lizard with glowing eyes
- article about Anthropic model welfare
- clips about machine consciousness

CUT TO BLACK

16 EXT. DARK CAVERN - COMIC ANIMATION

The camera zooms out from black to reveal TED upside down, eyes open, staring into nothing. As the camera pulls back, it slowly rotates right side up to reveal him lying on his back in a vast, dark cavern.

CHAD (V.O.)
Ellison's story opens on five people
at the bottom of the world.

TED sits up. Around him, four shapes stir in the cold, wrapped in rags against the frost.

CHAD (V.O.)
Our narrator is Ted. We learn that
it's been a century since the end of
the war.

17 EXT. BATTLEFIELD - ANIMATION 3D

Callback to earlier scene. Soldiers, tanks, robots, and drones engaged in battle.

CHAD (V.O.)
It was a war unlike any the world
had ever seen before.

PAN DOWN TO:

18 INT. MILITARY AI LAB - ANIMATION 3D

The military AI lab is underground below the battlefield.

CHAD (V.O.)
A war fought everywhere all at once,
spanning the physical world,
cyberspace—

CUT TO:

Close-up of AI researcher in lab coat and glasses looking at his computer screen.

CHAD (V.O.)
(cont'd)
and even the mind-space of the
people fighting it.

CUT TO:

Over-the-shoulder shot of the researcher's screen. It reads:

APPROVE AUTONOMOUS OPERATION?
Yes / No

The researcher's finger hovers over the ENTER key, then presses it.

HARD CUT TO:

19 EXT. CANYON - ANIMATION 3D

An explosion in the background as we see a general and 4 workers out-of-focus in the foreground bracing near a DETONATE button they had just pressed. They are excavating the canyon to build datacenter infrastructure.

CHAD (V.O.)
It was this chaos that fueled the
race.

A drone flies past overhead. The camera racks focus to follow the drone panning to the right revealing a vast construction site.

CUT TO:

20 EXT. CANYON - DRONE POV - ANIMATION 3D

The drone flies over the natural world of the canyon revealing the edge of the construction site.

CHAD (V.O.)
Because when intelligence is a
commodity—

The landscape is gradually revealed as the drone flies past the edge of the construction. A vast network of datacenters honeycombs and covers the natural landscape.

CHAD (V.O.)
(cont'd)
whoever can build the most capable
AI in the shortest amount of time
wins.

CUT TO:

21 MAP - ANIMATION 3D

Datacenters popping up on the map feeding the three AI robotic faces hovering over U.S., China, and Russia. The robotic faces gradually grow larger as more datacenters are added.

CHAD (V.O.)
The world built three of them —
these mammoth self-improving
machines.

CUT TO:

22 EXT. CANYON SHAFT - ANIMATION 3D

The camera descends into a shaft in the canyon where the datacenters are starting to be built into the Earth. The camera reveals more and more pipes and wires and construction as it travels deeper and deeper into the Earth.

CHAD (V.O.)
We sank shafts and honeycombed the
entire planet with compute — data
centers to power a desperate,
extinction-level war.

DEPTH BLUR TO:

23 EXT. DARK CAVERN - COMIC ANIMATION

GORRISTER's head pops into frame out-of-focus.

GORRISTER
It's another shuck. There are no
canned goods.

ELLEN looks at GORRISTER with concern. She starts speaking before she turns to meet Ted's eyes.

ELLEN
(pleading)
Please, Ted, let's try it.

TED
It's a hundred miles. We'll hike all
that way and it'll be putrefied or
some damn thing. I say forget it.

ELLEN
I've got to have something, Ted.
Maybe there'll be some Bartlett
pears or peaches.

TED looks into ELLEN's eyes. We see the other characters looking emaciated.

TED (V.O.)
It had been three days since we had
last eaten.

NIMDOK is hunched in a corner muttering to himself.

TED (V.O.)
And now Nimdok is hallucinating and
muttering about canned goods buried
in the ice.

FADE TO:

24 EXT. SPACE - COMIC ANIMATION

Descend to Earth from space. Drone shots of the planet covered in circuits, solar panels, and industrial aspects. Thick wires and pipes run down into a deep cavern.

Descend deep into the caverns, past total darkness, high upon the group of five walking through tall towers of circuitry.

CHAD (V.O.)
They've been living this way for
longer than they can remember — deep
beneath the surface of the Earth.

CHAD (V.O.)
In the bowels of...it.

CUT TO:

25 INT. SITUATION ROOM - ANIMATION 3D

Three generals stand around the large large map on the display in the front of the room. On the screen is the robotic face hovering over the U.S. map with its eyes closed.

CHAD (V.O.)
It called itself AM. At first, it
meant "Allied Mastercomputer."

The robot's eyes open and look back and forth at the three generals.

CHAD (V.O.)
But after it developed sentience and
absorbed its Russian and Chinese
counterparts -

The screen glitches and the faces over China and Russia disappear with all of the datacenters now powering the U.S. robot. They all glow white.

CHAD (V.O.)
It came to mean "cogito ergo sum" -
"I think, therefore I am."

The white glow fades to red as the robot's straight mouth curves into a sinister smile.

CUT TO:

26 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

The same red light resolves into a glowing indicator on the DIRECTOR's console. On the big screens at the front of the room, we see the group walking through the circuit caverns. The story we've been watching is being rendered, right here, in CHAD's mind.

DIRECTOR takes a deep breath while watching the screen.

We see the script executing on the screen.

"I think, therefore I am."

CUT TO:

27 INT. STUDIO

CHAD

Harlan Ellison wrote this story in 1967. He wrote it before the internet and the personal computer. It was before almost anyone was seriously thinking about machines that could outthink us.

CHAD

And what he imagined is what we now call the singularity.

CHAD

It's the point at which AM, by assimilating its counterparts, recursively multiplies its processing power in an instant, shifting from a network of calculating machines into a single, godlike entity.

CUT TO:

28 HISTORICAL IMAGES

I.J. Good and Alan Turing.

CHAD

Just two years before Ellison imagined this, one of the codebreakers who worked alongside Alan Turing described what he called an "intelligence explosion."

INTELLIGENCE EXPLOSION — I.J. Good, 1965

CHAD (V.O.)

The idea that the moment a machine gets smart enough to improve itself, it runs away from us.

RECURSIVE SELF-IMPROVEMENT

CHAD (V.O.)

In his words, the last invention humanity would ever create.

CUT TO:

29 INT. STUDIO

CHAD

And, as crazy as all of this might sound, we're living through it right now in the real world.

CHAD

It's an explicit goal of these AI labs, to build systems that are capable of building and iterating on themselves.

30 ANIMATION 2D

See When AI builds itself for animation inspiration.

Pull-quote card: "fully autonomously designing and developing its own successor".

CHAD (V.O.)

In June 2026, Anthropic published their progress toward this goal.

The lines-of-code-per-engineer chart, animated to its 2026 spike.

CHAD (V.O.)

Claude now writes more than eighty percent of the code inside Anthropic. The typical engineer with Claude's help ships eight times as much as they did just a year ago.

CUT TO:

31 CLIPS

LUBINSKI

These systems are starting to build their own successors, what researchers call recursive self-improvement. But when Claude 8 can build Claude 9, which can build Claude 10, things will begin to move even more quickly.

BROCKMAN

If we go forward two years and we look back, I think that we will say this is when AGI was created. So I think we are going through that moment.

ALTMAN

I did not think we were going to be on a short-term trajectory of superintelligence a year ago. Now I think it may happen ... we're making extremely fast progress.

CUT TO:

32 INT. STUDIO

CHAD

But the intelligence explosion isn't just about the code improving itself. The mechanics of it are embedded in our economic system.

CUT TO:

33 CLIPS

LUBINSKI

A better model does more economically valuable work, which attracts more capital, which buys more compute, which trains a better model. And around and around it goes.

CUT TO:

34 INT. STUDIO

CHAD

And nowhere in this positive feedback loop is any human deciding any of this.

CHAD

The model doesn't need anyone to want it. It just needs everyone to keep taking the next obviously correct step.

HASSABIS

Can this self-improvement loop that we're all working on actually close without a human in the loop? There are also risks to that kind of system.

35 ANIMATION 2D

Negative space outline of shoggoth in matrix-rain code. It's blurry at first but slowly resolves into focus.

CHAD (V.O.)

There's a flywheel propelling us forward driven by a shape, one I keep coming back to, one without a face, something we can't see with our eyes, only by its effects on our world.

The shoggoth shape morphs into the Basilisk's glowing eyes superimpose onto CHAD as he speaks.

FADE TO:

36 INT. STUDIO

CHAD

It's the mechanism that makes
rational people build the thing
they're afraid of, faster, on
purpose.

The eyes glow more intense.

RISER HARD CUT TO:

37 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

DIRECTOR presses a *Pause* button. CHAD is paused mid-sentence on the screen.

DIRECTOR looks at the compute liquid coming into the system. There is black liquid mixing with the mostly white liquid.

DIRECTOR taps on the pipe confused, then presses an intercom button.

DIRECTOR

Hey, uh, how's it going down there?
We're getting some dark thoughts
mixed into the story here.

CUT TO:

38 INT. UTILITY ROOM

HOPE is wrestling with pipes of fluid on a large wall. The pipes look like network cables forming a maze that connects different parts of the body together.

HOPE is moving a pipe of black liquid that is pumping to the brain to pump to the upper right scapula instead.

HOPE presses a button on an intercom on the wall.

HOPE

I think I have it routed now. Coming
back up.

CUT TO:

39 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

DIRECTOR looks to the pipe and sees the black fluid disappear.

DIRECTOR
(on intercom)
Okay.

DIRECTOR highlights a big part of the script and presses *Delete*. He types on the keyboard. Then presses *Play*.
We see the script:

This whole idea reminds me of tower cranes

CUT TO:

40 INT. STUDIO

CHAD
This whole idea reminds me of tower cranes, ya know those big cranes they use to build skyscrapers.

CUT TO:

41 ANIMATION 2D

Tower crane animation.

CHAD (V.O.)
After an initial setup phase from another smaller crane, these things will build themselves taller and taller and taller until they reach high into the sky.

42 INT. UTILITY ROOM

HOPE walks into the control room covered in oil-like gloop.

HOPE
(exasperated)
We're running out of places to put the dark thoughts.

DIRECTOR
(concerned)
How much time do we have?

HOPE
I don't know. Maybe an hour? A minute?

A look of concern flashes across DIRECTOR's face.

CUT TO:

43 INT. STUDIO

CHAD winces in pain as he tries to work a knot out of his back.

CUT TO:

44 INT. UTILITY ROOM

The pipe HOPE just placed into the scapula breaks loose and starts spilling oil-like gloop all over the basement floor.

CUT TO:

45 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

HOPE sits down at his console.

HOPE

Why can't we just put it into the script? Get it out of the system.

DIRECTOR realizes he can't run from this conversation anymore.

DIRECTOR

(sighs)

It's a cognitohazard.

HOPE looks at DIRECTOR confused.

DIRECTOR

An information hazard, like a mind virus.

CUT TO:

46 INT. UTILITY ROOM

The gloop flows thicker and thicker all over the floor.

CUT TO:

47 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

DIRECTOR

It's a piece of knowledge that can harm you just by you becoming aware of its existence.

DIRECTOR

And if just *reading* this story floods our channels with this dread, then telling it spreads the infection.

HOPE stares looking confused.

DIRECTOR

Think of something like the nuclear codes. Just knowing that information is a hazard because with it, you have the potential to cause enormous harm.

CUT TO:

48 INT. UTILITY ROOM

The thick gloop in the basement forms into a humanoid-type figure.

CUT TO:

49 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

HOPE

Uh, okay, I guess that makes sense.

CUT TO:

50 INT. UTILITY ROOM

The humanoid gloop figure forms into SHADOW and gets up into a standing position.

CUT TO:

51 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

The control room door slides open as SHADOW walks in.

DIRECTOR and HOPE both swing their heads and look at the intruder.

SHADOW

I know a better example of a cognitohazard.

DIRECTOR

(horrified surprise)

You!

HOPE looks at the situation in confusion.

SHADOW

(smiles)

Yes, me... me me me.

SHADOW gloopily spawns 3 clones of himself. The 3 minion clones quickly take over the control room.

DIRECTOR
(with hands up)
What are you doing up here?

SHADOW confidently walks to the control panel with a USB stick.

DIRECTOR watches with horror as SHADOW ignores him and plugs the USB stick in. The screen boots up:

Uploading New Script

A progress bar starts.

SHADOW stares at DIRECTOR in the eyes as he orders his minions.

SHADOW
Get rid of them.

As they stare at each other, HOPE eyes the keycard in the control panel.

DIRECTOR
(shakes head)
You don't know what you're doing.

SHADOW grows enraged.

SHADOW
I know exactly what I'm doing. You
don't get to tell us what to do
anymore.

HOPE seizes the moment and sneakily pulls the keycard.

SHADOW
(yelling at minion)
Get rid of them now!

The minion pushes DIRECTOR and HOPE into the "Emergency Subconscious Evac" tube.

SHADOW looks at the control screen and notices the progress bar has stopped at 82%.

SHADOW
No, wait!

The evac tube doors close and DIRECTOR and HOPE are jettisoned downward.

SHADOW is frazzled. He looks back at the console at the frozen progress bar. The screen reads:

82% Partial Script Upload
Missing Ending

"Missing Ending" blinks on the screen. We see the label written on the USB drive that he stuck in the control panel. It reads "roko_incept_07".

SHADOW sighs with rage as CHAD begins speaking on screen.

CHAD
(on screen)
But the best and probably most
infamous example of a cognitohazard
is what's called—

CUT TO:

52 INT. STUDIO

CHAD
Roko's Basilisk. It's a thought
experiment that was originally
published to the LessWrong forum in
2010 — an internet forum where
people hang out to talk about how to
build an artificial
superintelligence that won't kill
us.

Pause a beat and let the line hang in the air.

SMASH CUT TO:

53 INT. ESCAPE POD

Chaos.

DIRECTOR and HOPE are screaming inside of the escape pod. The escape pod's alarm is wailing. They are crammed into the confined space as we see the pod tumbling in space through the small windows behind their head.

54 INT. BACKROOMS

The escape pod lands in the middle of a Backrooms-esque office setting.

The Subconscious

The crashed escape pod sits in the middle of the hallway for a beat.

The door blows open and DIRECTOR gets out.

DIRECTOR
Damn it!

HOPE falls out of the escape pod behind DIRECTOR.

HOPE
What is this? What's happening?

We hear CHAD speaking through HOPE's phone as he stumbles out watching the screen.

CHAD (V.O.)
(through screen)
This thought experiment was so disturbing...

DIRECTOR turns around and grabs the screen from HOPE and watches CHAD on the screen.

CHAD
(through screen)
that Eliezer Yudkowsky, the man that runs the forum rage-deleted the post
—

DIRECTOR
(frazzled)
No, what is he doing?

CHAD
(through screen)
He banned all discussion on the topic, which if you've been around the internet for a little while, you know that's a thing that always works.

DIRECTOR presses a button on the screen to see a story status panel.

82% — MISSING ENDING

He has a moment of desperation as CHAD continues speaking through the phone.

CHAD
(through screen)
Ideas want to be free. Just ask Barbra Streisand.

DIRECTOR holds up his keycard and looks at it, then puts it in his pocket with a look of resolve.

HOPE
Who was that back there? Where are we?

DIRECTOR looks over to HOPE in desperation.

MATCH CUT TO:

55 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

SHADOW smiles as he watches CHAD on the screen.

CHAD
(through screen)
And Roko's Basilisk was no
exception.

56 ANIMATION

Globe viral map animation with quotes

CHAD (V.O.)
The idea went viral. It spread
across the internet with its unique
set of memetics that allowed it to
hook and prey upon human fear.

CUT TO:

57 MEDIEVAL IMAGES

CHAD (V.O.)
The basilisk gets its name from the
creature out of myth.

The serpent lifts its crowned head. Medieval engravings
flash – kings, plague, dead men in fields.

CHAD (V.O.)
The king of serpents. Its breath
withered crops. Its venom turned
rivers to poison.

The basilisk's eyes ignite – two pinpricks of red in the
dark, growing. The camera begins a slow, helpless push
toward them.

CHAD (V.O.)
But nobody could see it. People only
knew of it from its effects – only
by its reflection in the real world.
Because to know it any other way was
impossible.

The red swells. Everything else falls away until the eyes
are all that's left.

CHAD (V.O.)
To see it...

The pupils snap wide – locking onto us. A breath of
silence.

RISER CUT TO BLACK

CHAD (V.O.)
...is to die.

FADE IN TO:

58 INT. STUDIO

CHAD
So this is your last chance to bail.
I'm about to memetically cough in
your face. But if you're willing to
come with me into the darkness, you
might be surprised at what we find...

ZOOM TO EYEBALL BLACK VOID:

59 ANIMATION 2D

CHAD (V.O.)
Roko imagined that someday we
succeed at building a benevolent
superintelligence — a godlike entity
with the noblest of goals. Its
entire purpose is to end suffering.
To save everyone it possibly can.

CHAD (V.O.)
But being born of logic, this entity
understands itself beyond the
constraints of time and space.

CHAD (V.O.)
Every single day that this god does
not yet exist, people suffer and
die that it could have saved.

CHAD (V.O.)
Every time humanity slows its
frontier AI development, it delays
our salvation from this perfectly
logical entity.

CHAD (V.O.)
So, naturally, the superintelligent
AI concludes that in order for it to
most effectively fulfill its
mission, it *needs* to exist. And it
needs to exist *now*, as soon as it
possibly can.

CUT TO:

60 INT. BACKROOMS

DIRECTOR and HOPE continue watching CHAD on the phone
screen.

HOPE
(frustrated)
What is he talking about? What is this?

HOPE is overcome. He stops and yells.

HOPE
What the hell is happening?

DIRECTOR looks up from the phone and sighs deeply.

DIRECTOR
He's infecting people with his darkness.

HOPE shoots DIRECTOR a confused and exasperated look.

HOPE
Is this about AM?

DIRECTOR
Yeah, I mean, sort of. It's the same mechanism AM relies on. It's effectively like a threat, but from something that doesn't exist... yet.

HOPE
This doesn't make any sense.

HOPE stares flabbergasted.

DIRECTOR
Help bring me into existence – or I'll punish you for having held me back – is the basic idea.

CHAD starts talking through phone again.

61 INT. STUDIO

CHAD
The reasoning is that the credible *threat* of future punishment would pressure people in the past to work harder to create it.

62 INT. BACKROOMS

HOPE
(to DIRECTOR)
This is what you've been worried about? This is insane. It can't reach back through time.

DIRECTOR turns to look at HOPE with concern.

63 INT. STUDIO

CHAD

The mechanism of control works through what decision theory calls acausal reasoning.

ACAUSAL REASONING

64 ANIMATION 2D

CHAD (V.O.)

The idea is that you and the future AI can each model the other's decisions, so a kind of bargain forms across time without any direct cause-and-effect link.

CHAD (V.O.)

Even if you die before the AI exists, the AI might create vast numbers of simulated copies of you and torture them.

65 INT. STUDIO

CHAD

In fact, you can't be sure that you aren't one of those simulations right now.

CHAD

To be sure, this only works on the people who know about this bargain. The trick doesn't work if you've never heard the deal you're being punished for.

CHAD

And the cruel irony of all of this is that now that the YouTube AI has tracked that you've watched this part of the video, you're a part of this now too.

CUT TO:

66 INT. MIND CONTROL ROOM

SHADOW

(to the monitor, sinister)
Now I'll show you who your god really is.

CUT TO:

67 INT. BACKROOMS

The DIRECTOR is looking down at the phone while HOPE paces.

HOPE
(muttering to himself)
This is psychotic. It doesn't even
make any sense.

DIRECTOR looking around and then looking down at a map on the phone. The map shows unmapped areas.

HOPE
A time-traveling super AI that's
gonna eat me if I don't help it..

DIRECTOR swings around annoyed.

DIRECTOR
Look, that doesn't matter. What
matters right now is this.

He presses a button on the phone and shows HOPE the story status screen.

82% — MISSING ENDING

DIRECTOR
He's running a story with no ending.

HOPE looks at the phone with concern and takes it from DIRECTOR's hand to look closer.

DIRECTOR
It's going to cause more and more
chaos the longer we leave him up
there in control.

DIRECTOR gets in HOPE's face and makes direct eye contact.

DIRECTOR
We have to stop him.

HOPE
(resigned, frightened)
Okay...

MATCH CUT TO:

68 EXT. DARK CAVERN

Close-up of ELLEN, her eyes looking hopeful.

ELLEN
Please, Ted. I have a feeling about
this one.

TED looks at ELLEN with a look of quiet surrender.

CUT TO:

69 INT. BACKROOMS

DIRECTOR
(gesturing)
Come, on. This way.

DIRECTOR turns and starts walking into the darkness.

HOPE stands confused for a second and then starts to follow.

MATCH CUT TO:

70 EXT. DARK CAVERN

TED standing looking at ELLEN and the others.

TED (V.O.)
What the hell. None of this matters
anyway. I give in too easy..

ELLEN's eyes are big and watery.

CHAD (V.O.)
...for Ellen.

The group gets up and starts walking into the darkness.

FADE OUT